carts, ears twitching and tails switching, and hawks, their ferocity contained in their claws clenched around the arm-guards of their keepers. Bringing up the rear was the treasury, carried on elephants and camels, and the king's furniture, all transported by mules, and twenty-eight field guns. This immense procession, soon so large that it 'seemed to hide the earth', and extending over a breadth of 3 kilometres and 'filling the woods with a crowding multitude', was led, in the front, by a single drummer who laid down the marching beat. In addition to the staccato of the horses' hooves, the occasional fluttering wing, the feral, dense bodies of the moving elephants, and the subdued shouts of the soldiery, there was always the sound of the drum beat, far away in front of the emperor, sounding out a slow, regular rhythm, a long-drawn breath.

By the time the Padshah reached the first halt, the enormous Mughal tented encampment was already set up. As he dismounted and rushed towards his imperial tent, powerful shoulders rolling beneath the fine cotton of his qaba, Akbar was greeted by two long rows of elephants and cavalry, all the noblemen saluting him as he walked by. The layout of this enormous mobile city followed an exact pattern, so that within a few days, anyone walking through would 'know his way about the bazaars as well as he does about the streets of his own city'. The crimson imperial tent was laid out on flat ground, within a large open space, which was covered by carpets; next to it were the audience hall and the naqqara, covering 1,500 metres in length. The open space was accessible only to guards, who patrolled it continuously to ensure the privacy of the women. To the right were the quarters of Salim and his attendants and to the left, those of Murad. Behind these tents were the offices and the workshops and, further still, a separate bazaar set up for the Padshah, the princes, and the elite noblemen with not just grains, maize, pulses, and provisions but all kinds of merchandise so that 'these bazaars seem to belong to some wealthy city instead of to a camp'. The merchandise was available at cheap rates as Akbar sent runners ahead to inform merchants of his impending arrival and exempt them from all taxes and promise them generous rewards on his return from the campaign. These incentives and promises were crucial, for as historian Abraham Eraly has pointed out:

> The very movement of an army through the land caused damage to property and unsettled life, so people invariably fled from the army's path, like gazelles at the scent of the tiger…. the advance of